

*hunt, frequently the most pleasurable part of collecting. Many collectors shift from a self-focused state to what some have described as a “flow state,” a mental state in which the person is so absorbed in the activity that he or she is unaware of his or her surroundings—commonly experienced by an athlete at the height of physical exertion or by someone immersed in a game or project.*

*Watching a passionate collector at a flea market makes it clear that his or her state of consciousness is altered during “the hunt.” The person has little appreciation for anything going on around him or her; only the pursuit matters. When the acquisition occurs, it is accompanied by a wave of euphoria and appreciation of the object’s features, which become part of the story of the acquisition. Finally, the excited collector catalogs the object and adds it to the collection, arranging for its display. (Pages 54–55)*

I felt a twinge of discomfort and a sense of recognition reading these words. Replace the word “collector” with “couponer,” and it described my relationship with couponing in a nutshell. Each of my children has heard my dismissive tone at least once when we are in a store and I spot a special sale. “Just a minute, honey. I’m in the zone,” I’ve said in response to their urgent plea to go to the bathroom, visit the toy aisle, or whatever need they have conveyed to me at an inopportune time during my hunt for good deals. I’ve avoided taking them with me to a book sale, consignment store bag sale, or clearance sale precisely because of how I operate “in the zone.” I’ve definitely experienced the euphoria and have been known to artfully arrange a display of my wares and snap a photo to share with others. Yes, I am willing to concede that my obsession with coupons hasn’t always been healthy or wise and that the savings were sometimes only an illusion. There